‘Within a short time, while Shah Shuja and the English officers were still trying to devise a plan, many people had gathered in the city . . . The Ghilzais immediately pitched in without hesitating even a moment to unpack – the infantry with their bags of food still on their backs, and the cavalry with theirs in their saddlebags.’[17]

Already, late the previous night, Lady Sale had seen from her rooftop large numbers of armed Kohistani horsemen heading into town; now the stream of armed tribesmen pouring into Kabul from all directions and of all ethnicities swelled to a torrent. ‘Abdullah Khan Achakzai and Aminullah Khan Logari welcomed the armed volunteers who came dancing and drumming joyfully from all directions,’ wrote Mirza ‘Ata. ‘They gathered them under the battle standard of Islam outside the walls and ordered them to attack.’[18]

There had been around 300 rebels in the morning when the attack on Burnes’s compound took place; but within forty-eight hours some 3,000 fighters had assembled in the city; three weeks later, the numbers had swelled to an almost unprecedented 50,000 as a whole range of groups with quite different motives and grievances were mobilised to take on the British. Having arrived separately the different – and sometimes rival – groups made separate camps: in reality, especially at the beginning, the insurgents were never the united force the British imagined them to be. The supporters of the Barakzais took over the Shah Bagh, the crumbling remains of one of Shah Jahan’s old pleasure gardens. The Kohistani Tajiks based themselves in Deh Mazang, the eastern Ghilzais put up in the fort of Mahmud Khan, while the pro-Sadozai Royalists like Aminullah Khan Logari dominated the Old City. Most of the incomers were not from the Durrani elite but were instead drawn from relatively marginal groups: some were restless Pashtuns from the valleys and passes to the south and east of Kabul, from the Koh Daman and Logar, but it was perennially rebellious Tajik Kohistanis, deeply affected by the vicious punitive campaigns of Burnes and Sale the previous year, who initially seem to have made up the majority of the incomers, encouraged by their Naqsbandi pirs and especially by Mir Masjidi’s kinsman Mir Aftab, who marched in with a large party on the evening of 3 November. Some, such as the Logaris, arrived with their chiefs; others came as individuals, called to arms by the radical Sunni ‘ulema and encouraged by the rumours of rich plunder to be had. Shuja later wrote that he believed that ‘these men are not influenced by considerations